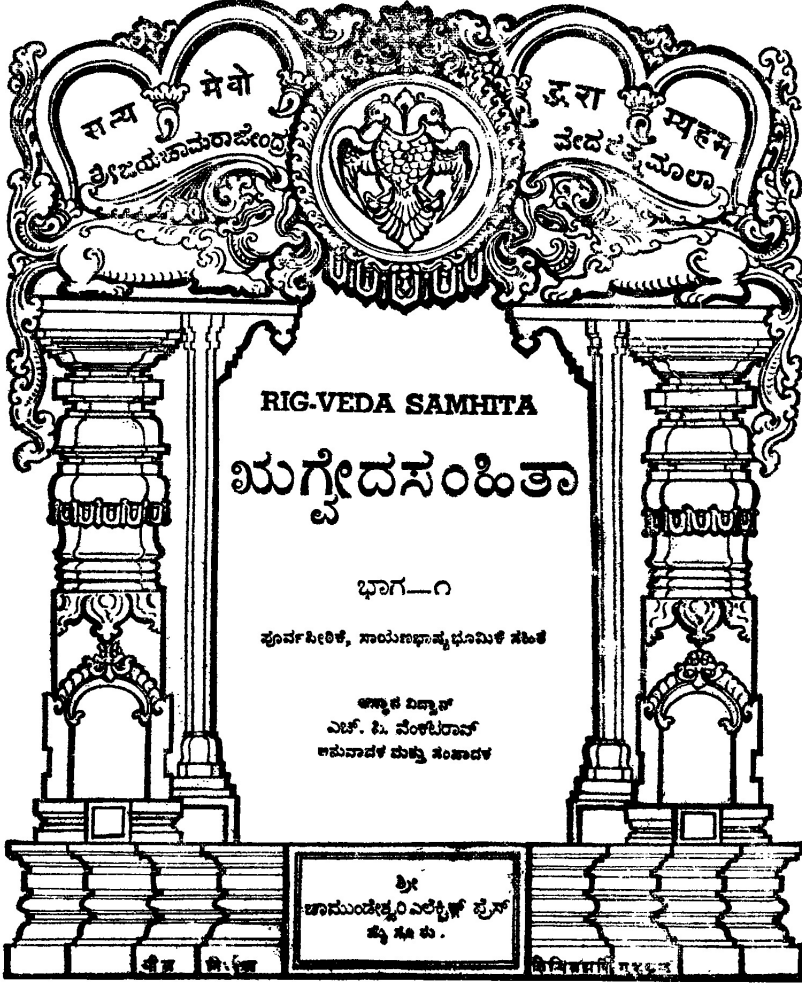


ವಿಷಯಾನುಕ್ರಮಣಿಕೆ



RGVEDA-SAMHITĀ · VOLUME 1 · ENGLISH
TRANSLATION

॥ श्री महागणाधिपतये नमः ॥

Ṛgveda-saṃhitā

*with the Bhāṣya of Sāyaṇācārya
and the Kannada Commentary of H. P. Venkata Rao*



VOLUME 1

*Pūrva-pīṭhikā · Sāyaṇa's Bhāṣya-bhūmikā · Maṇḍala 1,
Sūktas 1–2*



English Translation by
Bhargavi Upadhyā

prepared with the assistance of Claude, an AI model by Anthropic

Based on the Kannada edition of Asthāna Mahāvidvān H. P. Venkata Rao,

Editor

Śrī Jayacāmarājendra Vedaratna-mālā · Mysore, 1949

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This translation is based on the Kannada edition of the *Ṛgveda-saṃhitā with the Sāyana-bhāṣya*, edited and translated by Asthāna Mahāvidvān H. P. Venkata Rao and printed at Śrī Śāradā Press, Mysore, 1949, published by the gracious permission of His Highness Śrī Jayacāmarājendra Wadiyar Bahadur, G.C.B., G.C.S.I., Maharaja of Mysore. The ornate cover reproduced on the first page is from that edition.

The English translation was prepared with the assistance of Claude, an artificial-intelligence model made by Anthropic, working from scanned pages of the original. Readings that remain uncertain are marked [?] in the text.

[Publisher, ISBN, edition and printing details — to be supplied. Permissions status of the 1949 original and of the portraits — to be confirmed before publication.]

PATRON OF THE FIRST EDITION



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His Highness Śrī Jayacāmarājendra Wadiyar Bahadur, G.C.B., G.C.S.I.,
Maharaja of Mysore, by whose gracious permission the original edition
was published.

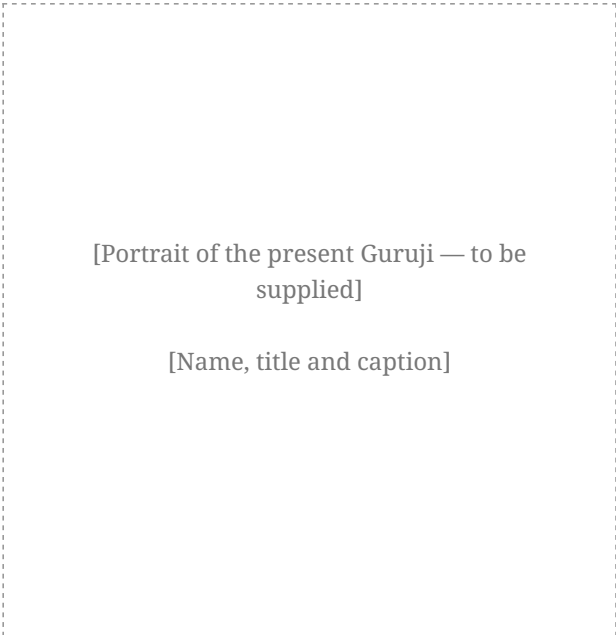
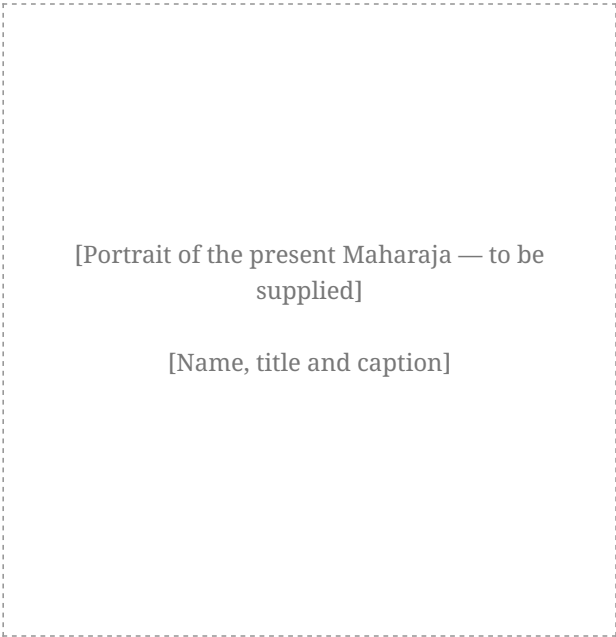
GURU & PRESIDENT OF THE BOARD OF SCHOLARS



ಶ್ರೀ ಜಗದ್ಗುರು ನಾಗಲಿಂಗಪರಿವ್ರಾಜಕಾಚಾರ್ಯ ಸೀತಾಪ್ತಪಾದ
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Śrī Jagadguru Nāgaliṅga-parivrājākācārya-pīṭhādhyakṣa
Śilpasiddhānti Śivayogi Śrī Siddhaliṅga Svāmigaḷavaru,
President of the Veda-vimarśana Vidvan-maṇḍali

THE PRESENT DAY



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Preface (ಮುನ್ನುಡಿ)

1

original p. i

There is no doubt that, in any country, the development of language and literature, and the composition of excellent, mature-class texts, produce a significant impact on the conduct and civilization of that country's people. The advancement of language itself is a hallmark of the progress of a nation's civic life. No other language has as many advanced treatises as Sanskrit does in poetry, drama, Vedanta, grammar, the arts, music, logic, and Mimamsa. Moreover, a large portion of Sanskrit texts are independent works — composed on their own without depending on another text — not translations from other languages. In earlier times such texts were in circulation, and the country had many traditional scholars devoted to them.

As time passed, the country came under foreign rule and grew fragmented, and — beset by disturbances and unrest — traditional education lost its earlier encouragement. Many excellent manuscripts, painstakingly written and collected by earlier generations, were destroyed for various reasons. Since mere survival became people's greatest concern, interest in this difficult field of study waned. This state of affairs continued for many centuries.

1. Note: This is a careful first-pass reading of a dense, old-typeface scan. A few proper nouns/titles are my best reading of the image and worth cross-checking against the original if precision matters (flagged inline with [?]).

About a hundred years ago, after India came under English rule, peace was established in the country, and the lethargy and despondency among the people gradually diminished; even as conditions returned toward their earlier state, the influence of English education brought about notable changes in people's conduct. People grew more interested both in learning English, the language of the rulers, and in imitating the civilization of other nations. Since Sanskrit learning offered no particular economic benefit and was difficult to pursue, ordinary people abandoned its study almost entirely; and, intoxicated with the little political/administrative language knowledge they had gained, they forgot their own earlier culture and glory, and even began to feel a quiet embarrassment about it. The importance of Sanskrit texts survived only in name here and there — known only to scholars, unknown to everyone else.

It was at such a time — when our own people, unable to understand our own texts, viewed them with indifference — that many German, French, and English scholars, with great effort, studied Sanskrit (a foreign language to them) systematically and revealed the greatness of Sanskrit texts to the world. Our people, who until then had been in a state of slumber, were awakened by the publications and research of these Western scholars, grew curious to know the importance of their own texts, and began to study Sanskrit in a new way. From then on, Sanskrit study received special recognition, and many texts that had lain tarnished in obscurity got the opportunity to come to light. The art of printing, which was just then developing and advancing...

original p. ii

...proved to be of great help to the publication of texts. Amid the study and research of Sanskrit texts, many German scholars — who took upon themselves the foundational and reverent task of researching Sanskrit texts of all kinds, going back to their most original and ancient forms — began, above all, to critically research and print the Vedas. Several Veda-related texts were first

printed in Germany itself. Many scholars devoted their entire lives to the research and publication of just one or two texts. Foremost among such scholars was the German scholar Max Müller. He is said to have spent the greater part of his life — some 30 years — researching and printing the Rigveda. Government support for Vedic studies was minimal; even so, many Western scholars, out of pure scholarly enthusiasm, undertook new research and rendered great service to their own countries through new publications. That a single text's research should take some 30 years to complete shows how immense the scale of such work can be. For this reason, it is a welcome sign that scholars of this country devoted to Sanskrit studies, Vedic studies, and research work are increasing in number.

Examining the state of the country closely in the present context, Sanskrit knowledge is not widespread among the common people — it survives only in a few places and to a small degree, which has not been of much help even to Sanskrit's own popularization. Therefore, however excellent Sanskrit texts may be, their usefulness has not reached most people. In earlier times, every individual was expected, as part of family tradition and as a higher duty, to learn Sanskrit; but given the present condition of the country, everyone recognizes this is no longer feasible. For this reason, many learned people of earlier and present times have found it useful to translate excellent texts into their own regional languages for the public's benefit. But such translated works remain few. Most texts remain untranslated, and there has been little encouragement for translating important texts into Kannada. Only a handful have so far been published for public benefit. Beyond the material support needed for publishing, this gap has persisted largely for want of encouragement to translate and print major works such as the Vedas.

It was Max Müller who first printed the Rigveda together with Sayana's commentary; in this first printing and research effort he received the generous support of the East India Company. This

first printing and research required contributions from many quarters, as the scholar himself has acknowledged. Building on this, further corrections and research were undertaken, and — having gathered materials thoroughly — a second edition, supported by the Maharaja [of Vijayanagara/a royal patron][?], brought together all available manuscript copies and, printing the complete text handsomely, made it available equally to all people as a public service.

original p. iii

Considering this earlier printing, it is well known that Max Müller and the Maharaja patron of that time together bore responsibility for this undertaking on behalf of the people. With the help of these two figures, Vedic scholarship progressed considerably beyond its earlier state — yet the present extent of that progress still leaves room for concern, which is a source of some regret. Working diligently and selflessly, only those scholars fortunate enough to receive royal or patron support were able to accomplish such significant work. In just this way, the great scholar and Vedic authority Sri Madhvacharya[?], together with his brother Sayanacharya, under royal patronage, composed a commentary covering the meaning of the Vedas for the benefit of scholars. Sayanacharya in particular, being versed from childhood in the Veda, grammar, Mimamsa, Shrauta, Vedanta, and related disciplines, undertook — with the assistance of several eminent scholars — the great task of composing commentaries on all four Vedas, rendering them in clear, accessible language for all, a work of great public service. The texts he composed remain, to this day, proof of his scholarly dedication to public benefit. Even where his commentary is unavailable elsewhere, there has been little difficulty in grasping the Veda's meaning — a measure of how far-reaching his contribution has been.

Even so, not everyone well-versed in Sanskrit can readily grasp the Veda's meaning unaided; and given that, only a fortunate few in the Kannada-speaking land who sought Vedic knowledge — grounded in the eternal foundation of dharma, inclined toward learning, and devoted to divinity — could turn to Sri Jayachamarajendra Wodeyar Bahadur (K.C.B., K.C.S.I.), the most eminent Maharaja, who, with the outlook of a great benefactor, undertook the foremost task of publishing Vedic texts — including the ancient, foundational Rigveda — together with Sayana's commentary, the meaning of the shruti texts, grammatical notes, and detailed annotations for scholarly review, rendered in clear style for ordinary readers, and handsomely printed, bringing to the people a trustworthy work of scholarship. Such a vast and beneficial undertaking would not have been possible for an ordinary person; it is known to all that only a great king devoted to dharma could accomplish it. Though many points of scholarly debate and deep philosophical matters remain, no other language has, until now, undertaken and completed such an unprecedented endeavor. Partial renderings of the Veda's meaning — brief or elaborate — have appeared in Marathi, Bengali, Hindi, and other languages, but printing several complete parts together in this manner has remained incomplete elsewhere, whether for lack of financial resources, lack of public encouragement, or other reasons — which is regrettable. Whichever language achieves such an unprecedented, complete undertaking in its own tongue should count it as great fortune — and no other language has yet achieved as complete a rendering of the Veda's meaning with such thoroughness. For this good fortune, and for making Kannada literature flourish and advance in every direction before the world, nothing more needs to be said in praise of the noble endeavor of our great benefactor, the Maharaja.

original p. iv

In Sanskrit texts, no other works hold a place as foremost as the Vedas. Whether one considers grammar, Mimamsa, literature, Vedanta, or any such discipline, all of them are ultimately grounded in the Vedas. As for why the Vedas are spoken of as four: examined from a discerning standpoint, all the Vedas together form essentially one body of work; even so, it is proper to treat them as four separate divisions of that one work, under the names Rigveda, Yajurveda, Samaveda, and Atharvaveda — much as a single text may rightly contain many chapters on different subjects.

Considered this way, the Rigveda's core mantras form the foundational verses of the entire Vedic corpus. The Yajurveda largely draws on the Rigveda's principal mantras to describe the methods of performing yajnas (sacrificial rites). The Samaveda likewise takes up the Rigveda's chief verses and adapts them, arranged to suit musical requirements, for chanting. Hence, in the performance of a yajna these three Vedas are all essential; none of them can be dispensed with. The Atharvaveda differs somewhat from the mantras of the other Vedas in many of its portions; many of its mantras appear to be later additions, and it does not follow the strict rules of chandas (meter) construction found in the Rigveda as consistently. Several mantras shared among the other three Vedas also occur in the Atharvaveda, yet it is not customary to use these in yajna-related rites. For this reason it is said that the Atharvaveda's mantras were composed after the first three Vedas, and it is regarded as a later, supplementary Veda.

From this description, the compilation collectively called "the Vedas" may be understood as one body of work discussing four distinct subject-divisions. But since each of these four divisions is, in its own right, an independent subject, it has become customary to speak of them as four separate Vedas. According to the proper method of Vedic study, one should ideally study all four Vedas. Where that is not feasible, one should at least begin self-study

and, within the time available, study the Vedas in due proportion — for studying only one Veda does not allow full knowledge of the subjects discussed across all of them. Since a human lifespan is not long, and in these times formal education is not organized so that students can undertake the study of the four Vedas, the Vedangas, and the Dharmashastra texts systematically from childhood, it has become common for followers of a given branch (shakha) merely to study their own single branch superficially, for form's sake rather than genuine mastery. In this way, the tradition of Vedic learning, as originally ordered by the sages, has been steadily declining generation after generation — and that decline continues even today. ²

original p. v

For general/public benefit, among those who directly undertook to explain the Rigveda's meaning, the sage Yaska was foremost. As he belonged to a very ancient period, his exact date cannot be fixed with certainty, but by any reckoning his work is reckoned to be no less than roughly three thousand years old. This suggests that even in his time, the Veda's meaning was evidently not easily accessible to people in general — which is itself telling, given the antiquity involved. It appears from his own text that several sages had directly engaged in explaining Vedic meaning even before him, though since the names of those earlier works are not known to us, nothing definite can be said about them.

Yaska's *Nirukta* holds a special place among the auxiliary Vedic disciplines (Vedangas); everyone agrees that its assistance is essential for understanding Vedartha (Vedic meaning). Within it there are two divisions — the *Nighantu* and the *Nirukta* proper. In the *Nighantu*, words carrying a shared meaning are grouped together and their common sense stated for the group. In the *Nirukta*, key root-words (dhatus) occurring in the mantras are

2. continuing the discussion — noting that these matters have already been treated in detail elsewhere, so they are not repeated here, though a few points on Vedic commentary deserve mention:

taken up, their meanings given along with their word-formation/etymology, and — drawing on other Vedic and historical context — the full connected sense of the mantras is explained. His work is accepted as authoritative by all. Western scholars, however, hold that his explanations — while following the actual words of the mantras — cannot always be confirmed as reliably capturing the sages' (rishis') original intended sense.

I have already discussed, in the introductory chapter (Peetika-prakarana), the main commentaries (bhashyas) available on the Rigveda. Among these, the commentary of Skandaswami, the commentary of Venkatamadhava, and Sayanacharya's commentary titled *Madhaviya Vedartha Prakashika* are the principal ones, and it is these that I have relied on here. Of the three, Skandaswami's commentary is the oldest. It explains each verse in simple, plain language, without delving deeply into grammatical technicalities — offering only a straightforward sense. This commentary is not widely available, and it differs from Sayana's commentary at several points of interpretation. Surviving copies are preserved in places such as Madras, Trivandrum, and a few other locations [place name partly unclear in the scan].

Venkatamadhava's commentary, by contrast, is quite detailed, offering word-by-word (pratipada) explanations and addressing grammar and Mimamsa matters as needed, rather than giving only a terse gloss. Because of this thoroughness, Vedic study has been made considerably easier with the help of this one commentary; its style is close in spirit to Sayana's. Having carefully examined, compared, and corrected this text — with extensive notes and explanations — a scholar (name reads as roughly "Sruthirupam Sarma" in the scan [?]) printed and published it in four parts.

original p. vi

Among the commentaries currently in use, Sayana's commentary is by far the foremost. In it, with the aid of etymological analysis, ancillary sciences, ancient historical context, Nirukta, grammar, Chandas, the Shrauta-sutras, and Mimamsa, each mantra is explained with detailed critical discussion, together with its ritual application (viniyoga) and its connection to sacrificial procedure — all treated at great length, though the language itself is somewhat difficult. Following context, he supports his interpretations with authoritative citations drawn from the four Vedas, the Brahmanas, the Upanishads, the Nirukta, the Shrauta-sutras, Panini's grammar, Jaimini's Purva-Mimamsa, and similar texts, arguing consistently and reasonably throughout.

Since this text was composed roughly six hundred years ago — an era when great Vedic scholars, though they appeared, were rare, and Vedic knowledge was not widely accessible to ordinary people — such a work could only have been undertaken with royal patronage (rajashraya). Records of that time show that scholars then were thoroughly trained not only in Vedic ritual practice but in many other shastras as well; only because of that level of traditional mastery could a work of such magnitude have been composed in that era. Composed under the title *Madhaviya Vedartha Prakashika*, and attributed to Sayanacharya, it is said that several lesser-known scholars assisted under his leadership in the undertaking — though for various reasons, the exact details of this collaborative authorship remain uncertain.

There is no need to dwell further on doubts surrounding the composition of Sayana's commentary. When Sayanacharya undertook to write the Rigveda commentary, he first laid the groundwork with an extensive introduction (Bhashya-bhumika) establishing the Veda's greatness — its authority (pramana), its eternality (nityatva), the sanctity of Vedic recitation, the value of Vedic knowledge, and other deep subjects — citing Mimamsa, grammar, and related texts as evidence, with extensive discussion. Only after this does he begin explaining the mantras

themselves: for each hymn (sukta), he gives its meter, the deity of its mantras, and their ritual application, before explaining each mantra's meaning fully, in line with context and historical background. He also explains the derivation of key words following Panini's grammatical rules, and cites the sentences of other Vedic texts as supporting evidence, using the methods of grammar and Mimamsa — this is characteristic of his style throughout, and it is this approach that has made the mantras' meaning accessible to scholars and ordinary readers alike with relative ease.

For this reason, in undertaking this Kannada rendering of the Rigveda, I have mainly followed Sayana's commentary, while also drawing, where relevant, on the views of other commentators and of modern Western Vedic scholarship. The method I have followed in this translation is as follows —

(1)

At the beginning of the book, in the introductory section (Peetika), I have gathered and discussed, in appropriate chapters, many subjects that a reader ought to know beforehand for the sake of Vedic understanding, compiled from numerous rare texts and their research, along with a general overview. Reading this introduction should leave no doubt or uncertainty about fully and correctly understanding matters relating to Vedic discussion.

original p. vii

(2) *The Bhashya-bhumika of Sayana's Rigveda commentary* — this introduction, written by Sayanacharya himself at the start of his commentary, establishes, with the help of Jaimini's Purva-Mimamsa, many deep points of Vedic discussion through logical reasoning and proof, and is essential reading for any serious student of the Veda. Through it, one comes to understand clearly the proper method of interpreting Vedartha, and where there is no room for misinterpretation — resolving doubtful and unclear points with precision.

(3)

After this, the explanation of the actual Rigveda mantras' meanings begins. Each sukta (hymn) is taken up in turn: its Mandala, Anuvaka, Sukta, and Rishi are given, along with divisions such as Ashtaka, Adhyaya, and Varga, and the number of verses (richas) it contains. The rishi, deity, and chandas (meter) of the mantras are likewise given according to tradition (Shruti), making it convenient to identify each mantra's sage, deity, and meter. For ease of recitation and reference, numbering is provided — the Mandala, Sukta, and Rig numbers at the top of the page, and the Ashtaka, Adhyaya, and Varga divisions at the bottom.

(4)

After this, the Samhita text itself (the mantra text) begins, each verse printed in bold, distinct type for easy identification.

(5)

Next comes the Padapatha — the word-by-word breakdown of the mantra — likewise printed in bold, distinct type.

(6)

Following this, Sayana's original Sanskrit commentary text is printed.

(7)

After that comes the Pratipadartha (word-by-word meaning), giving the correct sense of each word in accordance with Sayana's commentary. Where a mantra requires supplied/implied words (adhyahara) not literally present in the text, or where a meaning needs to be supplemented, this is shown clearly in brackets () for ease of understanding.

(8)

After the word-by-word meaning, the overall sense (Bhavartha) is given — the mantra's intended meaning as a coherent whole, written in flowing form.

(9)

Under the heading "English Translation," only the essential meaning of the mantra is given briefly, without unnecessary elaboration.

(10)

Explanations of special or particular meanings (Visheshartha) are given only where relevant, in the notes for that specific context.

original p. viii

(11)

As for further special topics — in the notes section for each mantra, I have included: the general meaning, the emotional/sentiment meaning, the specific meaning, differences from earlier commentaries, differences in the meaning of the same words as they occur in other mantras (read in context), matters relating to the deities, details connected with ritual (yajna) procedure, supporting citations from other Vedic or related texts, variant readings found in other commentaries, the views of other commentators, and the research and opinions of modern Western scholars, among other useful points, all discussed at length. This section also includes a good number of points that are the result of my own independent research.

(12) *Grammatical process (Vyakarana-prakriya)* — immediately after the word-meaning (Pratipadartha) section, wherever Sayana's commentary addresses word-formation by grammatical method, with sutra citations, I have presented this clearly, in simple Kannada, for all readers. I have mainly followed Panini's grammar, while noting, where well known, points of difference among other grammarians. Where necessary, I have described in careful detail the phonetic/accental (svara) rules used in the

commentary. Readers wishing to go deeper can consult the standard grammatical treatises for more. This grammar section has been contributed by the learned grammarian Brahmashri Vedabrahmashri Lakshminarayanacharya [name approximate from the scan].

(13)

At the end of the book, an alphabetical index of the mantras is provided, making it easy to locate where any given mantra occurs; cross-references are also given to indicate where the same mantra appears in other Vedas.

Every mantra, then, carries the nine components described above. Anyone reading through them might suppose the subject has been treated in its entirety — but that is not really so. What is offered here is but a single drop from the vast ocean of Vedic meaning. Across the centuries, highly capable scholars, each according to their own ability, have drawn on many authoritative texts and their own research to explain the Veda's meaning, yet no one has been able to accomplish this fully through individual effort alone, whatever the subject. Anyone who takes up such a great task for the public good should regard the effort itself as their duty, and leave its true fulfillment to the will of God.

Texts consulted in the composition of this work include ³:

1. Rigveda Samhita — with Sayana's commentary
2. Rigveda Samhita — with Skandaswami's commentary
3. Rigveda Samhita — with Venkatamadhava's commentary
4. Taittiriya Samhita — with Sayana's commentary
5. Taittiriya Samhita — with Bhatta Bhaskara's commentary
6. Maitrayani Samhita

3. titles below are transliterated; a few uncertain readings from the scan are marked [?]

Page xi (bibliography, continued)

1. Rigveda Samhita Parishishta
2. Rigveda Samhita Anukramani
3. Rigveda Sarvanukramani [?]
4. Shukla Yajurveda (Vajasaneyi) Samhita
5. Shukla Yajus — Madhyandina Samhita
6. Vedabhashya-bhumika Samgraha
7. Vedartha-yukti (first printing)
8. Vaidika Vangmaya Itihasa (Parts 1–2)
9. Samaveda Samhita
10. [Ashtiya/uncertain] Brahmanam [?]
11. Aitareya Brahmana
12. Taittiriya Brahmana
13. Shatapatha Brahmana
14. Shankhayana Brahmana
15. Shadvimsha Brahmana
16. Aitareya Aranyaka
17. Taittiriya Aranyaka
18. Atharva Samhita
19. Kaushitaki Brahmana
20. Taittiriya Upanishad
21. Atharva Parishishta
22. Anuvakanukramani
23. Ashtakanukramani
24. Rigveda Pratishakhya
25. Taittiriya Pratishakhya
26. Paniniya Shiksha
27. Katyayana Shiksha
28. Narada Shiksha
29. Bharadvaja Shiksha
30. Parashara Shiksha
31. Charanavyuha
32. Brihaddevata (attributed to Shaunaka)

33. Nirukta (composed by Yaska Maharshi)
34. Pingala Chandas-sutra Vritti
35. Vyasa Shiksha
36. Veda-sarva-bhasha Shiksha [?]
37. Sama Pratishakhya
38. Ashvalayana Shrauta Sutra
39. Apastamba Shrauta Sutra
40. Apastamba Paribhasha Sutra
41. Katyayana Shrauta Sutra
42. Baudhayana Shrauta Sutra
43. Drahayana Shrauta Sutra
44. Shankhayana Shrauta Sutra
45. Darshapurnamasa Prakarana
46. Adhana Samchaya [?]
47. Adhana Paddhati
48. Mahidhara's commentary (Bhashya)
49. Mantrārtha Manjari
50. Rigvastu and its commentary [?]
51. Narasimha Vivriti
52. Panini's Ashtadhyayi Sutras
53. Jaiminiya Purva-Mimamsa
54. Shabara's commentary on the Jaimini Sutras
55. Prabhakara's and Bhatta's (Kumarila's) commentaries on the Jaimini Sutras
56. The Mahabharata and the eighteen Puranas

...along with, among Western and German scholars, the critical works — and translations — on Vedic subjects written in English and German by Wilson, Griffith, Ludwig, Grassmann, Winternitz, Arnold, Keith, Max Müller, Peterson, Pischel, Roth, Geldner, Hillebrandt, Oldenberg, Rosen, Bloomfield, and others.

In carrying out this work of composition, it is my duty to gratefully and dutifully acknowledge the help received from the many scholars and learned persons named above.

At the unified pitha (Ekapeetha) of Karnataka, in the great and momentous cause of propagating dharma, presides the illustrious Jagadguru of the Shilpasiddhanta [sculptor-tradition] lineage — an embodiment of great learning — who occupies the throne of the Sri Sri Siddalingaswamigalu matha [names approximate from the scan; this appears to be the same pontiff pictured in the frontispiece]. His Holiness has made the whole of Bharata the field of his good works, and stands as the very foundation of true dharma (sanmarga) and scriptural authority. Holding that the eternal dharmas must be upheld and the Veda treated as the foremost, foundational authority — and that right conduct must be determined according to scriptural injunction, with the fruit of one's actions depending on rightly grasping that meaning — His Holiness, moved by deep compassion for people everywhere and by concern that the Veda, being difficult of access, should be made easy for all to understand, undertook this sacred task after long deliberation.

In accomplishing this, he received the support of many eminent teachers, statesmen, and elders devoted to learning. Notable among them was Sri Jayachamarajendra Wodeyar Bahadur (K.C.B., K.C.S.I.), who, recognizing the importance of this work for the country, together with several scholars devoted to Vedic study, gave leadership and sustained effort under His Holiness's guidance to see this great undertaking through — and it is thanks to the generous patronage of these benefactors that this publication venture was made possible.

This work, originally conceived on a scale of several thousand pages [exact figure unclear in the scan], is being published in several parts. The present part contains the introductory section (Purva-peethika); the parts that follow will present the essential meaning of the mantras of the four Vedas, keeping the treatment focused and free of excessive elaboration. ⁴

Page xi (closing of the Preface)

...having carried through this work of translation and publication for the all-round advancement of the Kannada language — with the encouragement of scholars devoted to Vedic learning, the general public, and Karnataka's own enthroned ruler, our benefactor Sri Jayachamarajendra Wodeyar Bahadur (K.C.B., K.C.S.I.) — we offer this prayer, with singular devotion, to the merciful and compassionate Lord, the very embodiment of the Veda (Vedapurusha): that He may graciously protect and preserve the health, prosperity, and lineage of the Maharaja, his royal family, and all his subjects.

**Mysore, Sarvajit-nama Samvatsara, Ashvayuja month,
Krishna Paksha — 24-10-1947**

*Translator and Editor, Court Scholar (Asthana Vidwan), Veda-
pandita Venkatarao.* ⁵

4. Page continues into an expression of gratitude and hope for the work's reception:

5. followed by the Mysore state emblem

Table of Contents — Rigveda Samhita with Sayana's Commentary: Introduction (Purva- peethika)

The next pages (17–18 of the PDF) are the book's own table of contents for the introductory section. Chapter titles and page numbers are translated in full; the very dense enumerations of branch/school (shakha) names under Chapters 5–7 are technical proper nouns (names of Vedic schools), given here as a transliterated list rather than individually annotated.

Purva-peethika (Introduction)

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Chapter 1 — "What is the Veda?"

The etymological derivation of the word "Veda"; a detailed account of the four Vedas beginning with the Rigveda. p. 4

Chapter 2 — Divisions of the Veda

The parts of the Samhitas — the Rigveda Samhita, its Mandalas, Anuvakas, and Suktas, and the number of mantras in each; supplementary (Parishishta) suktas; the Ashtaka, Adhyaya, Varga, and mantra-count divisions; the character of the Yajurveda — Shukla and Krishna Yajurveda; the Vajasaneyi Samhita, Taittiriya Samhita, Maitrayani Samhita, Kathaka Samhita; the branches of Shukla and Krishna Yajurveda; the Samaveda Samhita; the Atharvaveda Samhita and its branches; the Brahmanas of each

Veda (Rig-, Yajur-, Sama-, and Atharva-Brahmanas); the Aranyakas and Upanishads belonging to each Veda. p. 11

Chapter 3 — The Vedangas (Limbs of the Veda)

Shiksha, Vyakarana (grammar), Chandas-shastra (metrics), Nirukta, Jyotisha-shastra (astronomy/astrology), the Kalpa-sutras, the Shrauta-sutras (and which belong to which Veda), the Grihya-sutras, the Dharma-sutras, the Shulba-sutras, the Parishishtas, the Anukramanis (indices), and works such as the Charanavyuha and the Brihaddevata. p. 27

Chapter 4 — The Branches (Shakhas) of the Veda

The differences among the branches; the number of branches still extant; the nature of the differences between them. p. 44

Chapter 5 — The Branches of the Rigveda

The Acharya-shaila [lineage of teachers]; the main divisions currently prevailing; the Shakala branch and its sub-branches — the Mudgala, Galava, Shailiya, Vashkala, and Shaishiriyā branches; their extent; the Shakala Samhita; the Bashkala branches; the Baudhya branch; the Agnimata branch; the Sharashaka [?] branch; the Jatuka-karnya branch; the Bashkala Samhita; the Ashvalayana branches; the Shankhayana branches; the four sub-divisions of the Shankhayana; the Kaushitaka branch; the Mahakaushitaka branch; the Shambavya [?] branch; the Mandukeya branches; the Shaingya branch; the Baudhalaki branch; the Shailalaka branch; the Shatabalaksha branch; the Aitareya branch; the Vashishtha branch; the Sulabha branch; the Shaunaka branch; and a summary. p. 47

Chapter 6 — The Branches of the Yajurveda The Shukla and Krishna Yajurveda branches; the roughly 101 branches of the Shukla Yajurveda; the main divisions of the Madhyandina branch; the main divisions of the Kanva branch; the sub-branches

of Krishna Yajurveda — the Charaka branch and its sub-divisions; the subject-matter of the Vajasaneya branch; the main Vajasaneya branches — Jabala, Baudhya, Kanva, and the propagators of the Kanva branch; the Madhyandina branch and the chapters (adhyayas) within its Samhita; the Shapeya branch; the Tapaniya branch; the Kapola, Paundravatsa, Avatika, Parasumanta, Charaka, Vaidheya, and Kaundinya branches; the Vaijavapa branch; the summary of the Shukla Yajurveda mantras. ¹

Kauthuma branch, continued:

...Jaiminiya, Ranayaniya, Satyamugri, Naigeya, Yajnika, Shardula, Vanargani, Gautama, Bhallavi, Kalabavi [?], Shatyayana, Rauruki, Kapeya, Vanakasharanya [?], Kardikaka [?], Shandilya, and Tandya branches; the Tandya-Brahmana; the Kauthuma tradition (Samhiti) as a whole; and the composers of the Samaveda's mantras; the mantra-count of the Samaveda. p. 144

Chapter 8 — The Branches of the Atharvaveda

The nine branches of the Atharvaveda — Paippalada, Stauda, Mauda, and Shaunakiya — the extent and internal divisions of the Shaunakiya Samhita; the Sanchapata and Vaitika [?] branches; the Chunavala [?], Brahnavada, Devadarsha, and Charana-vaiddya branches; the mantra-count of the Atharvaveda; the various names by which the Atharvaveda is known; the ancient traditions/legends (agama-shastra) associated with the Atharvaveda. p. 157

Chapter 9 — The Brahmanas and Aranyakas of the Rigveda

1. continues below

The meaning of the word "Brahmana"; the two kinds of Brahmanas; the Anu-brahmanas; the Brahmanas of the Rigveda; other Brahmanas, including the Kaushitaki Brahmana; the Aranyakas of the Rigveda; the Shankhayana (or Kaushitaki) Aranyaka. p. 168

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Agni, Indra, Soma, the Ashvin deities, Mitra, Varuna, the Vishvedevas, Dyava-prithvi (Heaven and Earth), Savitr, Ushas, Surya, Vishnu, Pushan, Rudra, and details of other such deities. p. 205

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The defining characteristics of the meters, with examples; the specific features of Gayatri and its variants, Ushnih, Anushtubh, Brihati, Pankti, Trishtubh, and Jagati; the Pragatha and Sankirna (mixed) meters; the general principles defining meter. p. 221

Chapter 13 — The Commentators on the Rigveda

Skandaswami, Narayana, Uddhitha, Haskyamalaka [?], Venkatamadhava — the distinguishing features and style of Venkatamadhava's commentary — other Rigveda commentators including Jayatirtha, Narasimha's commentary, Raghavendra Yati's *Mantrartha Manjari*, Atmananda, and Sayana — Sayanacharya's own works, his Veda-commentaries and their introductions (bhashya-bhumikas) — an account of

Sayanacharya's commentary — Ravana, Mudgala, Chaturvedaswami, Devaswami, Bhatta Bhaskara, Uvata, Haradatta. p. 232

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Chapter 14 — The Commentators on the Yajurveda

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An examination of the Vedic era; the research undertaken by Western scholars on this question, along with their views. p. 336

— **The Introduction (Purva-peethika) to the Rigveda concludes here. —**

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The defining characteristics of *Parisamkhya* (exclusive specification, a Mimamsa technical category). p. 389

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A refutation, with logical proof, of the view that the Veda was composed by a human author, and a defense of the doctrine that the Veda is authorless (apaurusheyatva). p. 465

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A criticism of one who studies the Veda with no concern for its meaning, and praise for the value of knowing Vedic meaning. p. 520

A further explanation, in this connection, of certain quoted verses/phrases and related textual passages [specific Sanskrit citations, given in the original]. p. 527

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The purpose of Jyotisha-shastra (astronomy/astrology) and related matters. p. 583

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The characteristics of one who lacks the qualification for Vedartha-jnana; the duties of a disciple; the obligations of a teacher; how Vedic study bears no fruit if approached the wrong way even under proper instruction; and the qualities a disciple must have to truly grasp Vedic meaning. p. 588
[printed as 388 in the scan — likely a printing error, given the surrounding sequence]

— **Sayana's Bhashya-bhumika (Introduction to the
Commentary) concludes here. —**

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A summary of the structure of the Agnishtoma sacrifice. p. 667

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— **The Table of Contents concludes here.** — ¹

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¹. To be continued — the next batch moves into the actual body text of the Purva-peethika, Chapter 1: "What is the Veda?"

Key to Abbreviations

The book's footnotes/citations use these standard abbreviations for the texts it cites: ²

Abbrev.	Full text
Ath. Sam.	Atharvaveda Samhita
Apa. Su.	Apastamba Shrauta Sutra
Apa. Dha. Su.	Apastamba Dharma Sutra
Apa. Pa. Su.	Apastamba Paribhasha Sutra
A. Su.	Ashvalayana Shrauta Sutra
U. Su.	Unadi Sutra
Ru. Sam.	Rigveda Samhita
Ai. A.	Aitareya Aranyaka
Ai. U.	Aitareya Upanishad
Ai. Bra.	Aitareya Brahmana
Chan. U.	Chandogya Upanishad
Jai. Su.	Jaiminiya Purva-Mimamsa Sutra
Jai. Nya. Vi.	Jaiminiya Nyayamala-vistara
Tan. Bra.	Tandya Maha-Brahmana
Tai. A.	Taittiriya Aranyaka
Tai. Bra.	Taittiriya Brahmana
Tai. Sam.	Taittiriya Samhita
Ni.	Nirukta, Nighantu
Pa. Su.	Paniniya Sutra
Pa. Shi.	Paniniya Shiksha
Phi. Su.	Phit Sutra
Bra. Su.	Brahma Sutra
Ma. Bha.	Mahabharata
Ma. Smri.	Manu Smriti

2. and so on for others used in context

Abbrev.	Full text
Mai. Sam.	Maitrayaniya Samhita
Yaj. Smri.	Yajnavalkya Smriti
Va. Sam.	Vajasaneyi Samhita
Va. Pu.	Vayu Purana
Vi. Pu.	Vishnu Purana
Ved. Su.	Vedanta Sutra
Sha. Bra.	Shatapatha Brahmana
Sa. Sam.	Sama Samhita

PART I: Pūrva-pīṭhikā — the Introduction

Introduction (Pūrva-pīṭhikā)

Opening invocatory verse (a traditional Sanskrit shloka, not original to this author):

That syllable (Om) which is declared at the very start of the Veda, and which stands established at the end of the Vedānta — that which, dissolving into its own source, remains supreme — that is Maheshvara (Shiva). The Veda is Shiva, and Shiva is the Veda; one devoted to the study of the Veda is Sadashiva himself. Therefore, with every effort, one should always recite the Veda.

original p. 1

There is little need to dwell at length on just how essential it is to study the Vedas together with their meaning. For Indians — indeed, why single out Indians? — for anyone anywhere in the world who considers themselves civilized, studying the Veda with an understanding of its meaning is a foremost duty. However learned a person may be, however accomplished in the arts, if he has not understood the Veda even to some extent, his scholarship cannot be regarded as complete. This is because the Veda has served as the very foundation for the conduct, customs, and branches of learning such as music and literature, of civilized peoples down to the present day. It is true that there is a great difference between the ways of life of people who lived thousands of years ago and those of today's more refined societies. But even as people's conduct has gradually diversified over time, the Vedas — and the branches of learning that are their limbs and sub-limbs — have never failed to exert their

influence on both ancient and modern human life. Understanding, through careful examination, how society and human life were in Vedic times, and how they gradually arrived at their present state, therefore requires that every human being undertake the study of the Veda together with its meaning.

Gaining knowledge of historical matters, however, is not the only benefit of such study of these most ancient subjects. The Veda's important contents also hold a singular place with respect to both worldly and spiritual/transcendental matters, and in relation to the many ancient and modern schools of thought. Moreover, since Vedic Sanskrit holds a unique place among the world's languages, there exists no language older than it. It is far more ancient even than Greek, Latin, and other languages themselves considered ancient. Many of the words used in the Vedas are still found today — with only slight variation — in those languages, as well as in various European languages such as German, and in ancient Persian. Being proficient in every discipline, the Veda stands as a veritable treasury of knowledge; no other language possesses a text of comparable antiquity. The Rigveda is the most ancient text in the entire world — a distinction no other text can claim.

original p. 2

The Rigveda holds this distinction for a further reason as well. Ordinarily, over the course of several centuries, even a single text tends to undergo gradual alteration, absorbing differences through interpolation, and it is common for material from later texts to become mixed into it, both in content and in literary style — in many instances even a poet's personal opinion creeps in unnoticed, quietly shifting the very purpose for which the text was composed. With the Veda, this has simply not happened. Even in that most ancient era, before any written script existed, the Veda was transmitted — strictly according to tradition — orally from father to son, from teacher to disciple, without corruption of any kind. In every generation, whether the one doing the teaching or the one doing the learning, it has been the

practice, out of great vigilance, to preserve the pronunciation with a precision as unyielding as if fixed in stone, so that not even the smallest deviation could creep into the recitation. Because this discipline has been followed so meticulously across generations, whatever variant readings existed even when the ancient sages first composed the Vedic mantras have come down to us with those same variations intact, unaltered. Not even a single syllable of this Veda has ever been changed — nothing added to restore a supposed loss, nothing removed, nothing combined in from elsewhere. It has been considered improper, even in this modern age, to rearrange or reinterpret it for convenience, deriving whatever meaning one wishes according to context. Even where the opinions of ancient sages differed from one another regarding the Veda, both the wording and the pronunciation received from the ancients have been recorded without distortion. Even where a word's meaning was doubtful, or a different meaning seemed more fitting to a particular scholar, no one altered the received wording to suit personal judgment. No reciter, merely on the strength of private opinion, carelessly altered even a single word and thereby broke with tradition. Because of this, it has remained possible for us to know with precision exactly what the ancient sages themselves intended. Both in ancient times and today, countless eminent scholars, pandits, and learned families have devoted their considerable intellectual powers to Vedic scholarship, putting this to use across innumerable texts.

However, owing to the sheer difficulty of the subject, Sanskrit education — and serious engagement with Vedic study in particular — has not received the attention it deserves from Indians. Because many mistakenly regard Sanskrit as a "dead language," it is often dismissed without a second thought, and no importance is given either to the trouble of properly studying and understanding it, or to preserving accurate manuscript copies. Yet no other language possesses a literary treasury as rich as that of

Sanskrit. Disciplines such as logic, literature, Vedānta, history, and the arts exist in Sanskrit in a way unmatched by any other tongue. For many thousands of years, great scholars, expending extraordinary intellectual effort, have composed innumerable unrivaled works in this language. All of these texts are original and of the highest excellence — and, ancient as they are, none surpasses the Vedic scriptures themselves in antiquity. For this reason, scholars from Western countries such as Germany, England, and America have, for many years, applied themselves with dedication to studying this language — foreign to them — in a rigorous, scholarly manner... ¹

original p. 3

...the greatness of these texts, and have brought it before the world with genuine enthusiasm. Many Western scholars have devoted a large share of their own lives to Vedic scholarship, publishing numerous works and helping the world understand just how useful and important Vedic learning truly is.

Beyond this, in our own country, many scholars, learned assemblies, and royal patrons have, in various ways, encouraged Sanskrit and Vedic study — this is a happy state of affairs. And yet, has this borne fruit in proportion to the difficulty involved? Not entirely — because from the very outset, the study of scripture and grammar has not been made easy. For this reason, even those in this country who do study the Veda often do so without truly grasping it, merely reciting it by rote; and since its meaning is genuinely difficult to unpack, its practical value tends to go unrealized. Even great Sanskrit scholars do not always find the Veda's own language easy to understand — Sanskrit and the language of the Veda are not the same thing, and treating them as such is a mistake. This being the general situation even among scholars, how much less would an ordinary person be expected to

1. paragraph continues onto the next page

reflect on its interpretation? It is precisely to avoid this — reciting the Veda by mouth alone without understanding its meaning — that the sage Yaska is said to have declared, in his own Nirukta —

स्थाणुरयं भारहारः किलाभूदधीत्य वेदं न विजानाति योऽर्थम् । योऽर्थज्ञ इत्सकलं भद्रमश्नुते
नाकमेति ज्ञानविधूतपाप्मा ॥

स्थाणुर् अयं भारहारः किलाभूद् अधीत्य वेदं न विजानाति योऽर्थम् । *sthāṇur ayam
bhārahāraḥ kilābhūd adhītya vedaṃ na vijānāti yo'rtham* |
*yo'rthajña it sakalaṃ bhadram āsnute nākam eti jñāna-
vidhūta-pāpmā* | |

यद् दृग् ऋषीतमविज्ञातं निगदेनैव शब्दते । अनग्नाविव शुष्कैधो न तज्ज्वलति कर्हिचित् ॥

यद् ऋग् ऋषीतमम् अविज्ञातं निगदेनैव शब्दते । *yad ṛg ṛṣītamam avijñātaṃ
nigadenaiva śabdyate* | अनग्नाव् इव शुष्कैधो न तज् ज्वलति कर्हिचित् ॥
anagnāv iva śuṣkaidho na taj jvalati karhicit | |

उत त्वः पश्यन्न ददर्श वाचमुत त्वः शृण्वन्न शृणोत्येनाम् । उतो त्वस्मै तन्वं विसस्त्रे जायेव
पत्य उशती सुवासाः ॥

उत त्वः पश्यन् न ददर्श वाचम् उत त्वः शृण्वन् न शृणोत्य् एनाम् । *uta tvaḥ paśyan
na dadarśa vācam uta tvaḥ śṛṇvan na śṛṇoty enām* | उतो त्वस्मै
तन्वं विसस्त्रे जायेव पत्य उशती सुवासाः ॥ *uto tvasmai tanvaṃ visasre
jāyeva patya uśatī suvāsāḥ* | | (Rigveda 10.71.4)

(A further line or two continuing this same passage in the source remain too indistinct at this scan's resolution to transcribe with confidence, and are omitted rather than guessed at.)

Meaning:

One who undertakes Vedic study without understanding its meaning is, so to speak, merely carrying a burden like a piece of wood — deriving no real benefit from it at all. The second verse states this directly with its own image: a hymn recited by rote, without being understood, never blazes forth — like dry firewood set down with no fire, it never ignites. The third verse (RV

10.71.4) makes a related point about Speech (Vac) herself: one man, though he can see, has not truly seen Speech; another, though he can hear, has not truly heard her; but to another she reveals her very form, as an eager, beautifully adorned wife reveals herself to her husband — that is, her true meaning is disclosed only to the one who is genuinely receptive to it.

There is no end to the difficulty involved in a genuine critical study of Vedic meaning. As already noted, even a person highly accomplished in Sanskrit will not find the Veda's own language easy to understand. Alongside linguistic knowledge, one also needs the help of Mimamsa, grammar, Jyotisha (astronomy/astrology), and Vedānta. The meter and structure of Vedic mantras are not like the shlokas and verse-forms of later, more familiar poetry. Without understanding the Shrauta portion — that is, the actual procedure for performing yajnas and similar rites — the meaning of many words cannot be coherently grasped at all. For many words, interpreting them the way one would interpret classical or modern Sanskrit is simply not appropriate...

original p. 4

...does not apply in the same way [to Vedic mantras]. Case-endings, gender-forms, and similar features found in the mantras are not always strictly bound by grammatical rule. Because of these and other complicating factors, arriving at a critical interpretation of the Vedic mantras is not an easy task.

Given how much difficulty is involved, what benefit is actually gained by undertaking Vedic study? Is it merely to become familiar with imaginative stories? Or to learn descriptions of matters like time and place, as found in the works of great poets? Or is it rather to inquire into subjects concerning the self and ultimate reality, as Vedānta does? Whatever it may be — does it even exist within the Rīgveda, and how did the Rīgveda come to hold such scriptural authority? To answer this properly one must actually undertake the study, because the Rīgveda is an extremely ancient text. Since that era, it has shaped how the people of that

time worshipped their gods, performed yajnas, and conducted their society; it helps us understand how people lived, what they valued, and the hardships they faced. Understanding the ancient history of that society is a task worthy of every serious-minded person. For this reason, the Veda is, for us in India, an invaluable, all-encompassing text worth studying. It is held that the Veda is not human-authored (apaurusheya), and has come down uninterrupted from the mouth of Ishvara himself. Sayanacharya, at the very start of his commentary, argues this point at length with logical proof, so there is no need to elaborate on it further here. It is not possible, in this space, to discuss every subject contained in the Vedas — but those undertaking Vedic study should, as a preliminary matter, reflect carefully on a few essential topics.

Chapter One — What is the Veda?

What does "Veda" mean? To answer this, we look first at its etymology. The word "Veda" comes from the root *vid*, meaning "to know" — so "Veda" essentially means "knowledge." In ordinary usage, any treatise that thoroughly investigates a subject and instills complete understanding of it is called a *shastra*. The world has many such treatises — logic, Mimamsa, literature, the arts, and so on — and as new subjects continue to emerge, new treatises keep appearing to explain them. In an ultimate/absolute sense (paramarthika), however, "Veda" refers specifically to the knowledge that reveals the subject matter discussed in Vedanta — this is the sense in which the word has become fixed in Sanskrit. In this sense, Vedantic knowledge is what "the Veda" truly means, and this text is regarded as the original source for all such knowledge. Since this Veda came into being, many philosophical schools — dualist, non-dualist, and their many further subdivisions — have arisen from it. Now then: of what kind is this vast, ocean-like body of texts, and what are its defining characteristics? To find out is indeed our task.

The Etymology of the Word "Veda"

How did the word "Veda" come about? To trace this, one looks to the Samhita and Brahmana texts. The Charaka, Maitrayaniya, and Taittiriya Samhitas describe its derivation as follows:

वेदेन वै देवा असुराणां नित्यं वेद्यमुविन्दन्त तद्देवस्य वेदत्वम् ।

वेदेन वै देवा असुराणां नित्यं वेद्यम् अनुविन्दन्त तद् देवस्य वेदत्वम् *vedena vai devā*

asurāṇām nityam vedyam anuvindanta tad devasya vedatvam

"By the Veda, the gods repeatedly discovered/came to know the [hidden] nature of the Asuras — that indeed is the 'Veda-ness' belonging to the gods."

Summary:

The gods came to know the condition of the Asuras by means of this [knowledge]. Hence, it is called "Veda."

The Taittiriya Brahmana states the same. Words appearing in its authoritative passages — *anvinda* (knew/obtained), *avindan*, *avindata*, and *vividuḥ* — all derive, per Panini's grammar, from the root *vid*l, meaning "to obtain" or "to find." Bhatta Bhaskara, writing on the Taittiriya Samhita, indicates the same view, with a technical grammatical note explaining the word as formed with the instrumental-sense suffix *ghañ*, carrying an acute accent on the final syllable — "that by which something is obtained." A similarly worded citation is found in the Taittiriya Brahmana as well: *vividuḥ* = *labdhavantah*, "those who have obtained."

From works of the Atharvana tradition:

Anandatirtha, in a text on the nature of the ultimate reality, cites an authority to show the word's derivation — its gist being: the senses cannot know the Self (Atman), nor can inference know it; only the Vedas make it known. For this reason, they came to be called "Vedas."

From Ayurveda:

An authority is found here too. The Sushruta Samhita states:

आयुस्मिन् विद्यते अनेन वा आयुर्विन्दतीति आयुर्वेदः ।

आयुर् अस्मिन् विद्यते अनेन वा आयुर् विन्दति इति आयुर्वेदः āyur asmin vidyate anena vā āyur vindati iti āyurvedaḥ* (Sutra-sthana 1.24)

"That in which longevity (ayus) resides, or that by which one obtains longevity — hence, Ayurveda."

That is: longevity resides within it, or one obtains longevity by means of it — hence it is called Ayurveda. Dallana, the well-known commentator [on Sushruta], expresses the same view.

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A certain consistency emerges from this. According to Sushruta and his commentator Chakrapani, the word is formed with the suffix *ghañ*, used both in an instrumental sense and in a locative sense. Dallana notes that the root *vid* carries four meanings: "to exist," "to know," "to gain," and "to deliberate" — and it is from these that Sushruta's commentators derive the etymology of "Veda." The Charaka Samhita similarly holds that because one comes to know longevity through it, it is Ayurveda; its commentator Chakrapani explains *āyu vindati* ("obtains longevity") as "reveals longevity" — hence Ayurveda. In short: *vid* means "to know," and "Veda" derives from this root.

Among Atharvana-tradition scholars, similar derivations are offered by other writers as well [a passage here is too indistinct in the scan to render with confidence]. Kshirasvamin, commentator on the Amarakosha, writes: *vidanti jñena dharmam vedah* — "they know dharma through this; hence, Veda" (1.4.6) — and other commentators similarly gloss it as "that by which one knows dharma and related matters." The Jain scholar Hemachandra, in his *Abhidhana-chintamani*, gives an equivalent formula. Thus, several scholars argue that "Veda" arises from the root *vid* in the sense "to know."

Medhatithi, commenting on the Manu-smṛiti, explains along similar lines: that the meaning of dharma, unknowable by any other means, is known through this text — hence it is called "Veda." Elsewhere, it is explained that the Veda makes known the bliss of liberation (moksha-sukha) that comes through the relinquishing of action; and Haradatta likewise glosses it simply as *vedayati iti vedah* — "that which makes known is called Veda."

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In the introduction to his own Rigveda commentary, Dayananda Sarasvati writes as follows:

विदन्ति-जानन्ति विद्यन्ते भवन्ति, विन्दन्ति अथवा इन्दन्ते-लभन्ते, विन्दन्ति-विचारयन्ति । सर्वे मनुष्याः सर्वाः सत्यविद्या यैर्येषु वा तथा विद्वांसश्च भवन्ति ते वेदाः ।

विदन्ति = जानन्ति; विद्यन्ते = भवन्ति; विन्दन्ति/इन्दन्ते = लभन्ते; विन्दन्ति = विचारयन्ति. सर्वे मनुष्याः सर्वाः सत्य-विद्या यैर् येषु वा तथा विद्वांसश् च भवन्ति ते वेदाः. *vidanti = jānanti; vidyante = bhavanti; vindanti/indante = labhante; vindanti = vicārayanti. sarve manuṣyāḥ sarvāḥ satya-vidyā yair yeṣu vā tathā vidvāṃsaś ca bhavanti te vedāḥ.*

"They know; they come to be; they obtain; they deliberate. Those [texts] by which, or in which, all people come to possess all true knowledge and become learned — those are the Vedas."

The main point: from the earliest Samhitas down to the present, "Veda" has consistently been derived from a root meaning "to know," "to be," "to obtain," or "to deliberate" — every author works out the word's grammatical derivation by determining which suffix applies. Hariprasād, however, in the preface to his *Veda-sarvasva*, argues that a locative-sense construction, or derivation from roots meaning "to be," "to obtain," or "to deliberate," would be improbable or meaningless — yet on close examination of the cited authorities, the word's derivation is clearly reasonable regardless.

In any case, "Veda" has consistently been used to refer to the Vedic Samhitas themselves; other interpretations some commentators offer serve no purpose for the present discussion. Commentators explaining the Samhitas hold that "Veda," in this specific sense, refers to the mantra-Samhitas — though many scholars hold that mantra and Brahmana together constitute "the Veda," a view that is itself quite ancient. The Hiranyakeshi Shrauta-sutra states:

शब्दार्थमारम्भणानां तु कर्मणां समाम्नायसमाप्तौ वेदशब्दः ।

शब्दार्थ-मारम्भणानां तु कर्मणां समाम्नाय-समाप्तौ वेद-शब्दः *śabdārtha-mārambhaṇānām tu karmaṇām samāmnāya-samāptau veda-śabdaḥ*

"The word 'Veda' [applies to] the complete, traditionally-transmitted corpus of those rites whose word and meaning are set forth."

That is: whatever rites are established by valid means and enjoined through verbal authority — the word "Veda" denotes the complete corpus of such injunctions. Yadavaprakasha, author of the *Vaijayanti* lexicon, holds a similar view — that "Veda" applies collectively to mantra, Brahmana, and Kalpa together — though this definition is broad and rather formal.

It is, in truth, impossible to give a fully satisfactory single definition of "Veda." Even Sayanacharya, in the introduction to his own great commentary, acknowledges the difficulty of stating the Veda's defining characteristic with precision, concluding in the end that "Veda" means the collective totality of mantra and Brahmana together...

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...as he states. But then — what exactly is "mantra"? What is "Brahmana"? Or, within the Veda, what portion actually counts as "mantra"? This too has long been debated and is not free of controversy; defining "mantra" is no easy matter. Sayanacharya determined that the statements used to direct the various priests in performing the acts of a yajna, together with sentences that take the form of praise addressed to deities, constitute the correct defining mark of "mantra" — everything else is termed "Brahmana." Two Mimamsa-sutras support this position, to the effect that such statements are called "mantra" in the Veda, and the remainder is called by the term "Brahmana."

Though mantra (Samhita) and Brahmana differ considerably in style, meter, and subject matter, the two together are called "the Veda." The Veda is used chiefly in yajnas, which ordinarily

require four principal officiants: the Hotr, the Adhvaryu, the Udgatr, and the Brahma. Some hold that the Veda was divided into four parts to suit these four priests; others hold that the four Vedas together form one complete body of text, of which the Rigveda and the others are simply distinct portions treating distinct subjects. To perform a yajna, the Rigveda, Yajurveda, and Samaveda are all necessarily required — a yajna cannot be performed with the mantras of only one Veda.

In the most ancient period, only the Rigveda existed; the Yajurveda and other Vedas did not yet exist in their present form. In that era, Rigveda mantras alone were used both to invoke the gods and to make fire-offerings to them. To invoke a deity, a mantra called the *purōṇuvākya* was recited; to direct the actual offering, a mantra called the *yājyā* was recited — both had to be Rigveda mantras; mantras from any other Veda would not do. Even the chants used in the Samagana — later designated as "Samaveda" mantras — were originally Rigveda verses, simply set to Samavedic musical notation for singing. Thus, in the Rigvedic era, Yajurveda mantras were not yet in use. As the procedure for yajnas gradually became more refined and rule-bound, the statements recited alongside the mantras as context required — injunctions ("this act must be done thus"), explanations, and other such utterances — for each yajna...

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...were at first recited independently on each occasion rather than existing in a fixed form. Over time, these statements became systematized into what we now know as Yajurveda mantras — this is the most plausible account of its origin. In the Rigveda, verses beyond what the Hotr needs serve little purpose, and the same is true of the Samaveda; but the Yajurveda contains numerous statements clearly showing its dependence on both — for instance, phrases like "*ṛcā me dve*" ("two Rig-mantras are mine") and "*ayam u śya vā eṣa yaḥ sāma*" ("this indeed is what is

Sama") explicitly acknowledge this dependence. This is also why the Yajurveda's literary style is markedly less refined than the Rigveda's.

During the fire-offering, the Hotr priest invokes the deities using Rigveda mantras — typically two per deity: the *purōṇuvākya*, to invoke, and the *yājyā*, to direct the offering. But it is not the Hotr who actually pours the oblation into the fire — that task belongs to the Adhvaryu, who performs many other duties in the yajna as well and must be thoroughly versed in its procedures. It is for this that the Yajurveda is essential to him. The Udgatr performs the Samagana (chanting); it is said the deities are pleased by this chant and thereby accept their due share in the yajna — without it, the yajna is considered incomplete. The Brahma priest must oversee that every part of the yajna proceeds correctly according to rule, and for this must be familiar with all four Vedas. Accordingly, the Hotr is expected to have studied the Rigveda, the Adhvaryu the Yajurveda, and the Udgatr the Samaveda; the Brahma alone must know all four. These four are the principal ritviks (officiants) of a yajna.

The Rigveda, Yajurveda, and Samaveda are called "Vedas" in connection with these three priestly roles; together they are well known as the *trayī*, "the triad of Vedas" — a long-established designation. The Atharvaveda, however, places great emphasis on securing worldly benefits and prescribes rites for obtaining specific desired results. For this reason — along with the Brahma's need for comprehensive knowledge — the Atharvaveda too came to be regarded as necessary for the Brahma priest, some holding it as specifically his Veda above the other three.¹

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Because mantra and Brahmana are held to have no human author, texts belonging to the Veda are called "Shruti," while texts that depend on the Veda are called "Smriti." The Vedas are called

1. To be continued.

"Shruti" ("the heard") precisely because, in ancient times, people preserved them solely by oral transmission — hearing and reciting — never by writing. In that era, committing the Veda to writing was not customary at all; indeed, it was considered a transgression, out of concern for corrupting the purity of transmission, to render the Veda into a written or book form for general use. Only Brahmins, Kshatriyas, and Vaishyas held the authority (*adhikara*) to study it, and it was preserved only within specific family lineages — never written down anywhere. Even great poets such as Kalidasa never rendered these mantra-and-Brahmana texts into written form. The Veda has no named human author: sages such as Vishvamitra, Vasishtha, and Vamadeva are called the "rishis" of particular mantras only in the sense that those mantras became manifest to them — they are the "seers," not the authors, of the mantras, which they then taught to their disciples, from whom the tradition spread further. For this reason, the Veda is called *apaurusheya* (authorless), and, for these reasons, it bears the name "Shruti." The four Vedas are divided as follows:

Texts of the Vedanga class and other works that depend on the Veda are called "Smriti," itself divided into Sutra-texts and Kavya-form (narrative/poetic) texts. Of these, only the Sutra-texts are directly connected to the Veda; texts on Kalpa and similar subjects fall into this category insofar as they are essential for understanding the Veda. The Vedangas — Shiksha, Vyakarana, Chandas, Nirukta, Jyotisha, and Kalpa — are the Veda's six limbs, serving as aids to understanding Vedic meaning and to the practical use of Vedic mantras. These Vedangas are discussed further in a later chapter.

Chapter Two — Divisions of the Veda

There are four Vedas: Rigveda, Yajurveda, Samaveda, and Atharvaveda. Let us examine each carefully. Of the four, the Rigveda is by far the most important and the most ancient. Many Rigveda mantras recur throughout the Yajurveda, Samaveda, and especially the Atharvaveda. In the Samaveda, apart from a small number of mantras, virtually all the mantras are themselves drawn from the Rigveda. [The text here explains why the Rigveda is given priority] — one should give the Rigveda first place, since even in studying and learning the meaning of all four Vedas, and even in the mere recitation of the root text, this priority holds, on the strength of the following:

तस्माद्यज्ञात्सर्वहुतः ऋचः सामानि जज्ञिरे । छन्दांसि जज्ञिरे तस्माद्यजुस्तस्मादजायत ॥

तस्माद् यज्ञात् सर्वहुतः ऋचः सामानि जज्ञिरे । छन्दांसि जज्ञिरे तस्माद् यजुस् तस्माद् अजायत
॥ tasmād yajñāt sarvahutaḥ ṛcaḥ sāmāni jajñire | chandāṃsi
jajñire tasmād yajus tasmād ajāyata || * (from the Purusha-
sukta, Rigveda 10.90.9)

"From that all-oblation sacrifice were born the Rig verses and the Sama chants; from it were born the meters, and from it the Yajus came into being."

That is: from the sacrifice performed by the gods, the Rigveda arose first, then the Samaveda, then the meters, and only after that the Yajurveda. The Taittiriya Samhita states:

यद्वै यज्ञस्य साम्ना यजुषा क्रियते शिथिलं तदग्निश्च तद्दृढम् ।

यद् वै यज्ञस्य साम्ना यजुषा क्रियते शिथिलं तद् ऋग्भिश् च तद् दृढम् *yad vai yajñasya sāmṇā yajuṣā kriyate śīthilam tad ṛgbhiś ca tad dṛḍham*

"Whatever part of the yajna is performed loosely by Sama and Yajus [alone] is made firm by the Rig[-verses]."

That is: performing the rites of a yajna according to the Rigveda makes them more stable than performing them by Sama and Yajus alone. The Chandogya [Upanishad] states:

ऋग्वेदं भगवोऽध्येमि यजुर्वेदं सामवेदमाथर्वणमिति ।

ऋग्वेदं भगवोऽध्येमि यजुर्वेदं सामवेदम् आथर्वणम् इति *ṛgvedaṃ bhagavo'dhyemi yajurvedaṃ sāmavedam ātharvaṇam iti*

"Venerable one, I have studied the Rigveda, the Yajurveda, the Samaveda, and the Atharva[veda]."

Since the Rigveda is named first here, it is given the foremost position. For these reasons, the Rigveda holds greater importance than the other Vedas.

Each of the Vedas named above has four portions: Samhita, Brahmana, Aranyaka, and Upanishad. Let us first examine the Samhita portions.

The Samhita Portions — The Rigveda Samhita

The Samhita portion of the Rigveda is the most ancient portion of any of the Vedas. "Samhita" means the section formed by gathering the mantras — the suktas — composed by various rishis and arranging them in a fixed order in one place, with the rules of e

Collected Notes

*Every translator's note and editorial remark of this volume,
gathered by Sūkta and Rik.*

Preface (ಮುನ್ನುಡಿ)

1. Note: This is a careful first-pass reading of a dense, old-typeface scan. A few proper nouns/titles are my best reading of the image and worth cross-checking against the original if precision matters (flagged inline with [?]).
2. continuing the discussion — noting that these matters have already been treated in detail elsewhere, so they are not repeated here, though a few points on Vedic commentary deserve mention:
3. titles below are transliterated; a few uncertain readings from the scan are marked [?]
4. Page continues into an expression of gratitude and hope for the work's reception:
5. followed by the Mysore state emblem

Table of Contents

1. continues below

Sayana's Commentary with the Rigveda Samhita

1. To be continued — the next batch moves into the actual body text of the Purva-peethika, Chapter 1: "What is the Veda?"
2. and so on for others used in context

Introduction (Pūrva-pīṭhikā)

1. paragraph continues onto the next page

Chapter One

1. To be continued.